ambitious double-digit growth targets for minerals, the Zimbabwe government claims it will establish a Sovereign Wealth Fund, attract FDI, establish special economic zones, continue using the multi-currency system, implement value-addition ('beneficiation') strategies and ensure improved electricity and water supply. This will also require the re-capitalisation of the Minerals Exploration Company, Zimbabwe Mining Development Corporation and Minerals Marketing Corporation of Zimbabwe.

BRICS investments will be needed, but the past decade has seen highly controversial precedents. BRICS corporations make up Zimbabwe's top three investors: China leads with investments of US$375 million approved by Zimbabwe Investment Authority (ZIA) in 2013, followed by Russia with approvals worth US$40 million and, third, South Africa with US$39million. Next door in Mozambique, Brazilian and Indian corporations are not far away – in Tete Province – digging coal and displacing the peasantry on a vast scale.

China

Since 2000, China has been Zimbabwe's biggest foreign investor. ZIA records show that from 2010, investments contributed 72% of total FDI, or US$670 million, from a total of US$930 million worth of projects. In 2012, China's cumulative investments in the mining sector (mostly in gold, diamonds and chrome) totalled US$583 million, or 62% of the total US$688 million FDI approvals for the entire Zimbabwean mining industry last year.

China is unapologetic about the fact that its aid and investment are not tied to political or economic conditions. Such conditions, when imposed by the US or Europe, typically mix liberal democratic provisions with structural adjustment. The latter policy was imposed on Zimbabwe, and in part accepted by President Robert Mugabe's government during most of the 1990s. They failed, as in most of Africa, but unusually, Mugabe bucked the trend of acquiescence from 1997, during a series of social uprisings, and he has since zigzagged between authoritarianism and concessions to the majority.

Like the West, China seeks Africa's natural resources but its investments are not conditional upon achievement of minimal human rights and democratic objectives. There continue to be reports of human rights abuses perpetrated by Chinese employers against their Zimbabwean employees, and the resources from China's co-owned ventures in the diamond mines are reportedly responsible for the war chest that helped Mugabe hire an Israeli firm, Nikuv, to undermine the integrity of the July 2013 elections, which he won handsomely.

China has become a major player in the country's economy through joint